Prof. David Ubilava
Food Policy and The University of Sydney
July, 2023

Prof. Ubilava,
Thank you for inviting me to review Manuscript D-23-00433 "Revisiting Elasticities of Sweetened Beverages in Colombia." Here I provide my comments to the authors and yourself as the journal's co-editor. I welcome any further questions or comments.

In this paper, the authors report an exercise wherein they estimate the price and income elasticities of Sweetened Beverages in Colombia, which they find to be -0.5 and 0.88, respectively. They use data from the 2017 Colombian National Survey of Income and Expenditures (*Encuesta Nacional de Presupuestos de los Hogares*, ENPH), which includes expenditure on food at the household and individual levels. Methodologically, they replicate the approach in Deaton (1988 AER) which introduced a method to estimate price elasticities of demand using cross-sectional household survey data. The idea is that this methodology adequately addresses a wide range of potential biases. The authors suggest that their estimations have implications for the design of taxation targeting sugar- and non-sugar-sweetened drinks in Colombia.

1 Comments for the authors

Even if all of the concerns I mention here were to be addressed by the authors, I still consider the contribution of the current manuscript to be too small to merit publication at *Food Policy*. That said, I can see how the appropriate estimation of elasticities can be a component (an input) of a larger project addressing the potential effects of beverage taxation in Colombia.

1. There is no review of previous literature. This failure to locate your paper within the relevant literature, further complicates identifying your contribution.
2. Please, provide a detailed description of the ENPH. Including a description of the expenditure categories related to sweetened beverages; this description should report mean, standard deviation and other appropriate descriptive statistics by income group or geographical region. In sum, you have to take steps to make sure your audience becomes familiar with the survey and the spending habits on SBs by Colombians.
3. In the manuscript, you imply that your estimates improve on previous estimations, but no benchmark is given to the readers. What are these previous estimations and how does your methodology specifically differs from theirs.
4. Related, you need to provide some background. Most of your readers will not be Colombian, so they lack the institutional background knowledge to understand what you mean when you talk about other surveys that you did not use or what the status of soda taxation is in your country.
5. You frame their work around possible taxation of SSBs, but do not illustrate how their exercise can be applied to inform current debate (what do we do now that we know price elasticity is -0.5? By how much would consumption decrease? Which groups would benefit or be harmed by a tax? How much revenue could be generated?).
6. Limit your use of jargon because at times it makes it very difficult to read your writing (e.g. "off-market," "bias of unfeasible consumption"). Limit your use of acronyms as well.

Sincerely,
Reviewer - *Food Policy*